

The Fast of the Apostles

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This fast, also known as the Fast of Peter and Paul in some traditions, is one of the four canonical fasting periods in the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church and other Oriental and Eastern Orthodox Churches. It follows the celebration of Pentecost (the descent of the Holy Spirit) and varies in length each year because it begins on the Segno, after Pentecost (which is movable) and ends on 5 Hamle in the Ethiopian calendar), the Feast of Saints Peter and Paul.

1. The Fast of the Apostles: Meaning

The Fast of the Apostles holds profound meaning:

Thanksgiving and Preparation: It is primarily a fast of thanksgiving for the gift of the Holy Spirit received at Pentecost. Just as the Holy Spirit descended upon the Apostles, empowering them for their ministry, this fast allows the faithful to prepare themselves to receive and cultivate the gifts of the Spirit in their own lives.

Emulation of Apostolic Zeal: It serves as a commemoration and emulation of the Apostles' own fasting and prayer as they prepared to go out and preach the Gospel to the world. It's a spiritual discipline to ready oneself for active service in God's kingdom.

Spiritual Warfare and Dedication: Fasting, coupled with prayer and almsgiving, is a powerful tool in spiritual warfare. It helps to subdue the passions of the flesh, sharpen spiritual discernment, and dedicate oneself more fully to God's will, mirroring the dedication of the Apostles.

Focus on Mission: It reminds the Church of its ongoing apostolic mission to spread the Gospel. By participating in this fast, the faithful unite themselves with the spirit of the first missionaries of the Church.

2. Historical Origin (Biblical Canonical)

The historical and biblical basis for this fast is rooted in the practices of the early Church, directly following the example of the Apostles themselves.

Biblical Foundation:

The most direct scriptural reference pointing to the Apostles fasting specifically in preparation for ministry is found in the Book of Acts:

Acts 13:2-3: "As they ministered to the Lord and fasted, the Holy Spirit said, 'Now separate to Me Barnabas and Saul for the work to which I have called them.' Then, having fasted and prayed and laid hands on them, they sent them away."

This passage clearly shows the Apostles fasting before embarking on a major missionary journey, seeking divine guidance and consecration. This is the cornerstone for the Fast of the Apostles.

While Christ Himself fasted (Matthew 4:2), He also indicated that His disciples would fast after His departure:

Matthew 9:14-15: "Then the disciples of John came to Him, saying, 'Why do we and the Pharisees fast often, but Your disciples do not fast?' And Jesus said to them, 'Can the friends of the bridegroom mourn as long as the bridegroom is with them? But the days will come when the bridegroom will be taken away from them, and then they will fast.'" This prophesied the era of the Church, where fasting would become a regular discipline.

Acts 14:23: "So when they had appointed elders in every church, and prayed with fasting, they commended them to the Lord in whom they had believed." This shows the continued practice of fasting in the apostolic ministry, particularly in significant ecclesiastical acts like ordinations.

Canonical and Patristic Tradition:

The practice of a post-Pentecost fast is ancient. Early Church documents and Fathers attest to it:

The Apostolic Constitutions (late 4th century) mention a fast after Pentecost.

Saint Athanasius the Great (4th century) in his festal letters refers to a fast following Pentecost, encouraging believers to fast after the joyous period of the fifty days.

Saint Leo the Great (5th century) delivered sermons on this fast, emphasizing its importance for spiritual purification and preparation for bearing spiritual fruit.

The tradition solidified early on, connecting the reception of the Holy Spirit with the immediate need for spiritual discipline to effectively carry out the Spirit-empowered mission. The varying length is because Pentecost is a movable feast, but the end date (Feast of Saints Peter and Paul) is fixed.

3. Why the Apostles Fasted

The Apostles fasted for several crucial reasons, setting a precedent for the Church:

To Seek Divine Guidance and Discernment: As seen in Acts 13:2-3, fasting was a means to quiet the noise of the world and their own desires, making them more receptive to the voice and direction of the Holy Spirit regarding their ministry.

Preparation for Spiritual Endeavors: Before undertaking significant tasks like missionary journeys (Acts 13:3) or ordaining leaders (Acts 14:23), fasting was a way to consecrate themselves and the work to God, seeking His blessing and power.

Spiritual Discipline and Subduing the Flesh: Following Christ's example and teachings, the Apostles understood fasting as a way to discipline the body and bring it into submission to the spirit (1 Corinthians 9:27). This enhances spiritual alertness and strengthens one against temptation.

Intensified Prayer: Fasting often accompanied prayer, making it more fervent and focused. It was an expression of their earnestness and dependence on God.

To Set an Example: Their actions served as a model for the nascent Christian communities, demonstrating the importance of these spiritual disciplines in the life of a believer and the Church.

4. What Blessings They Received

Through their fasting and prayer, the Apostles received abundant blessings:

Clear Divine Revelation: The Holy Spirit spoke directly to them, guiding their decisions and commissioning them for specific missions. (Acts 13:2).

Spiritual Empowerment: They were filled with power and boldness to preach the Gospel, perform miracles, and establish churches even in the face of persecution. Fasting helped channel the power of the Holy Spirit they had received.

Success in Ministry: Their missionary journeys were fruitful, leading to the conversion of many and the expansion of the Church throughout the known world.

Divine Protection and Provision: Despite facing numerous dangers and hardships, God protected and provided for them in their apostolic endeavors.

Wisdom and Authority: They were granted wisdom to teach, lead the Church, and address complex doctrinal and practical issues, as seen in the Council of Jerusalem (Acts 15).

Endurance and Perseverance: Fasting built spiritual resilience, enabling them to endure suffering, imprisonment, and ultimately martyrdom for the sake of Christ.

5. And We, Why Do We Fast?

Christians today fast during the Fast of the Apostles, and other fasting periods, for reasons that echo the Apostles' motivations and align with the timeless purpose of fasting:

Obedience to Church Tradition: The Orthodox Church, guided by the Holy Spirit, has established this fast as a canonical practice. Participating is an act of obedience and faithfulness to the "faith once delivered to the saints." (Jude 1:3).

Spiritual Growth and Purification: Fasting helps to purify the soul and body from worldly attachments and sinful passions. It weakens the "old man" and allows the "new man" in Christ to grow stronger.

To Seek God's Will and Grace: Like the Apostles, we fast to become more sensitive to God's guidance in our lives, to seek His grace in our struggles, and to ask for His intervention in specific situations.

Repentance and Humility: Fasting is an act of humility before God, acknowledging our sinfulness and our need for His mercy and forgiveness. It is often accompanied by confession.

Strengthening Prayer Life: Fasting concentrates the mind and spirit, making prayer more focused, fervent, and effective.

Solidarity with Christ and His Saints: By fasting, we unite ourselves with Christ's own fasting in the wilderness, with the fasting of the Apostles, and with the countless saints who have practiced this discipline throughout history.

Preparation for Service: Just as the Apostles fasted before ministry, we fast to prepare ourselves for serving God and others in our own vocations and daily lives, asking for the Holy Spirit's empowerment.

Spiritual Warfare: Fasting is a crucial weapon against demonic influences and temptations (Mark 9:29 – "This kind can come out by nothing but prayer and fasting.").

6. The Blessings We Receive from Our Fasting

When undertaken with the right spirit (humility, prayer, repentance, and love), fasting yields numerous blessings:

Closer Communion with God: By detaching from worldly comforts and focusing on spiritual things, we draw nearer to God and experience His presence more profoundly.

Increased Spiritual Sensitivity: Our spiritual "senses" become sharper, allowing us to discern God's will more clearly and to be more aware of the spiritual realities around us.

Victory over Passions and Temptations: Fasting helps to tame the desires of the flesh (gluttony, lust, anger, etc.), giving the spirit greater control and making us stronger against temptation.

Peace of Soul and Joy: True fasting, combined with prayer and good deeds, brings an inner peace and a quiet joy that the world cannot give.

Answered Prayers: While not a magical formula, sincere fasting often accompanies fervent prayer that God graciously answers according to His will.

Fruits of the Spirit: Fasting cultivates the ground of our hearts, making it more fertile for the fruits of the Spirit: love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control (Galatians 5:22-23).

Humility and Compassion: Experiencing voluntary deprivation can make us more humble and more compassionate towards those who suffer involuntary hunger and hardship, often leading to increased almsgiving.

Health Benefits: While not the primary goal, disciplined fasting can have positive effects on physical health, which in turn can support spiritual clarity.

7. Conclusion

The Fast of the Apostles is a blessed and ancient tradition, deeply rooted in the actions of the very founders of our faith. It is not merely an abstention from certain foods but a holistic spiritual endeavor involving intensified prayer, repentance, almsgiving, and a conscious effort to draw closer to God. By participating in this fast, we honor the memory and example of the Holy Apostles, seek the continued outpouring of the Holy Spirit in our lives and in the Church, and prepare ourselves to be more effective witnesses of Christ in the world. It is a time to re-dedicate ourselves to the apostolic mission, empowered by the same Spirit who guided them, seeking the abundant blessings that come from disciplined spiritual effort.

Glory be to God; Amen!